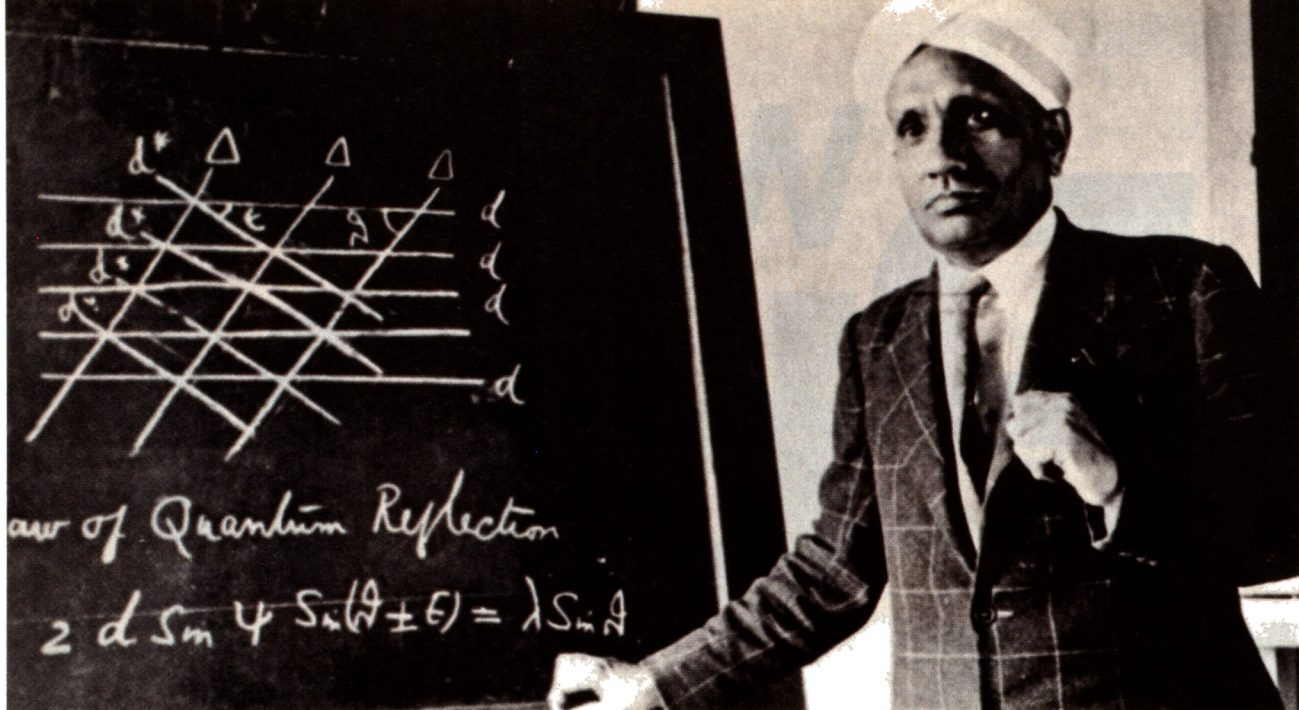




NML ARCHIVES

Premier league:
C.V Raman was the first Indian scientist to get a Nobel Prize in Physics in 1930

operations that the West has ceased to take interest in. India may have more than 270 universities but by the most charitable ranking of the *Times Higher Education Supplement*, our IITs rank 50th in the world, the IIMs 84th, and the much talked-about Jawaharlal Nehru University a lowly 192nd. In contrast, Peking University stands 15th. Even Fudan University in China, at 72, gets a better grade than the Jawaharlal Nehru University. It is no use saying that China has achieved all this because it does not have a democracy.

We all know, or should know, by now that endogenous growth takes place when R&D is locally produced and applied. If we take a look at Scopus or the Citation Index, Indian scientists and scholars have put up an unimpressive show. India figures badly in citations in *Nature*, the most acclaimed science journal. The country was not always this way. Indian intellectuals were prominent and, in many cases, at the cutting edge of knowledge well before Independence. This was possible because people like Sir Ashutosh Mookerjee were at the helm of affairs on the educational front. In the 1907 convocation of Calcutta University, Mookerjee had this to say: "From now on the (Calcutta) University is not just an institution issuing certificates, nor is it even a conglomeration of colleges... It will be a centre of learning and the expansion of the frontiers of knowledge." Accordingly, he encouraged high science in Calcutta University. He never argued

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IS WHAT INDIA SPENDS ON RESEARCH AND DEVELOPMENT, A PATCH ON CHINA'S EXPENDITURE OF \$216 BILLION.

that since India is a poor country, it is not capable of sophisticated sciences. We are often fed such arguments today, particularly by a few UN agencies. Mookerjee brought in people like C.V. Raman, Satyendranath Bose, Sisir Mitra and Meghnad Saha. All these scholars were recognised not just in India but internationally as well.

Calcutta University became a knowledge hub since it encouraged research.

We could have easily kept up this performance. With so many universities, institutes of sciences, IITs and IIMs coming up after Independence, there was no reason why we should have been sitting out in the bleachers and not out there in the centre field. In the course of time, Nehru's many temples of knowledge have become clearing houses for the mediocre and the standards were set so low that almost anybody could get a college degree. Instead, the attention of Parliament, politicians and the general public is on teaching. Statistics are sought on how many MAs, BAs and PhDs we produce, instead of examining the quality of the students we are granting degrees to.

So if there is one big idea we can pursue, and pursue realistically, then that is to put our might, mouth and money where R&D is. Let us not be satisfied with the mere production of graduates and post-graduates, but concentrate instead on doing high science. It is this endeavour that would alone stand guarantee for sustained economic growth for the future.

The author is a well-known sociology professor at the Jawaharlal Nehru University.

Bottom of the Ladder

INDIA MAY HAVE OVER 270 UNIVERSITIES, BUT OUR TOP INSTITUTES LIKE IITs AND IIMs ARE LOW DOWN IN THE RANKING COMPARED TO THEIR GLOBAL COUNTERPARTS